Week 3 Teacher Guide: Good Intentions Are Not Enough

The Obedience of Faith, Week 3 of 12.

Companion to Week03-GoodIntentionsAreNotEnough.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Show from Uzzah and his companions across Scripture that sincerity cannot substitute for God's revealed will; the governing question of worship is "Has God spoken?"

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves holding one distinction and one question. The distinction: *sincerity and success are both real, and neither is the standard.* The question: "*Has God spoken?*" If they can state those two things and defend them from Uzzah and from Moses' rock, the week succeeded. The six-case table is evidence for the pattern, not a memory assignment: nobody needs to recite all six.

Where this sits in the arc: Week 2 ended on "Saul had layer three and thought it was layer four." Week 3 is that single sentence expanded to the length of the whole Bible: the recurring human substitution of our judgment for God's word. It is also the *last* of the three diagnostic weeks. Next week the course turns to grace (Romans 10), so this lecture should press hard on the diagnosis while pointing forward: we are naming the disease now; the cure is Unit II.

A tone warning, read this first: this is the week most easily preached as harshness: an angry God zapping people over technicalities. That reading is false, and it will lose half your class. The point is never that God is severe about details; it is that God's *holiness* is real and man's presumption is real, and that God, precisely because He wants union (Week 1), tells us how to approach Him rather than leaving us to guess. The severity in these accounts is the exception that reveals the stakes, recorded so the pattern could be seen. Teach reverence, not fear of tripwires.

Presentation

Segment 1: Uzzah and the New Cart (0:00–12:00 · Slide 2)

Set the scene generously; do not make David careless. The intent was honor. The goal was right: the Ark belonged in Jerusalem. There was real joy and thousands worshiping (2 Sam 6:5). This matters: if the class hears "David was sloppy," they miss the lesson, which is that *sincere, joyful, well-intentioned worship went wrong.* The failure is not the opposite of devotion; it lives inside devotion.

The tell to point out (first click): the new cart was exactly the method the *Philistines* had used to return the Ark decades earlier (1 Sam 6:7–8). It was a sincere improvement (clean, costly, respectful), borrowed from the surrounding culture rather than drawn from the Word. Keep that observation; it is the seed of the discussion question about "new carts today."

God had already spoken (second click): the Ark travels on poles, on the shoulders of Levites, and is never touched (Ex 25:14–15; Num 4:15; 7:9). The instructions were not obscure or lost. They were skipped, not defied; nobody consulted them.

The touch was not the beginning (third click). Uzzah's reach is the most understandable motion in the account: the oxen stumble, the sacred thing tips, he steadies it by reflex. That is exactly what makes the passage hard, and you should say so honestly. But the problem started at the loading dock, not at the stumble. The cart made the touch inevitable; poles on shoulders would never have put a hand near the Ark. **The touch was the moment an earlier, quieter failure came due.**

David's own diagnosis (fourth click): months later he does it right (1 Chr 15) and names the first failure exactly: "we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance" (15:13). **Your class read this in advance** (Week 2's assignment pointed them here). Let someone say it before you put it on screen. The diagnosis belongs to David, under inspiration, not to us being fussy. Not "we lacked sincerity." Not "our motives were wrong." *We did not seek him the way he said.*

Transition: "Uzzah is not a special case, and this is not an Old-Testament mood. It is a pattern that runs the length of Scripture."

Segment 2: The Repeating Pattern (12:00–28:00 · Slide 3, the table)

The whole table appears at once, deliberately. The class needs to *see* the pattern, not have it revealed one row at a time; six cases stacked in a grid make an argument that six sequential slides would not. Walk it verbally, roughly two and a half minutes per row, but keep the pace honest; the payoff is cumulative.

- **Nadab and Abihu** (Lev 10:1–3): offered "strange fire… which he had not commanded them." Scripture never questions their sincerity or their priesthood; they were Aaron's sons, freshly ordained. The verse God speaks over the ashes: "Among the ones close to me I will show myself holy" (10:3). Worship belongs to the One worshiped, not the worshiper.
- **Saul at Gilgal** (1 Sam 13): the army was scattering, Samuel was late, the Philistines were massing. Every pressure said *act now.* Urgency felt like justification. It wasn't. Say clearly: the situation was genuinely hard, which is the point. Real pressure does not authorize unauthorized worship.
- **Saul at Amalek** (1 Sam 15): last week's man; one sentence. Sacrifice offered as a substitute for the command. "Obedience is better than sacrifice."
- **Moses and the rock** (Num 20): **the keystone case; land it hardest.** God said speak to the rock; Moses struck it. And the water *came out*, abundantly, for the whole congregation. The method was wrong and it *worked.* And Moses was still barred from the land he had spent

forty years reaching. If your class remembers one row, make it this one: **a successful result does not prove divine approval.** This is the proof-text for discussion Q1.

- **Jeroboam** (1 Kgs 12): golden calves, new feast days, new priests, alternative worship centers. Here is the uncomfortable part: his changes *solved a real problem*. If his people kept going to Jerusalem to worship, his kingdom would reunite with the south. The innovation was politically shrewd and it worked for generations. Scripture's name for the whole shrewd success: "the sin of Jeroboam." Pragmatism replaced revelation.
- **Uzziah** (2 Chr 26): a genuinely good and successful king, decades of faithfulness, who decided to burn incense in the temple (a priestly act, not a royal one). Competence in one God-given sphere did not license redefining another. Leprosy to the day he died.

The takeaway note (bottom of slide, read it last): never a lack of zeal. Urgency, success, and political wisdom were all real in these accounts; none of them authorized the change.

Transition: "Surely this severity is an old-covenant thing, and the New Testament relaxes it. It does not."

Segment 3: The Same Warning in the New Testament (28:00–38:00 · Slide 4)

- **Mark 7:6–9** (first click): Jesus quoting Isaiah: "they worship me in vain, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men." *In vain* means empty, to no effect; the worship happens and accomplishes nothing. The engine of vain worship is naming human commands as if they were God's. Jesus does not condemn the sincerity of the Pharisees (it was considerable); he condemns the swap.
- **Ananias and Sapphira** (second click, Acts 5): the point is *timing*. This is the newborn church, the Spirit freshly poured out, and the first recorded internal sin is counterfeit devotion: the appearance of a whole gift with a lie inside it. If God's concern for how He is approached were merely old-covenant severity, Acts 5 would not exist.
- **Corinth** (third click, 1 Cor 11:20): "when you come together… it is not the Lord's Supper you eat." Every external element was present: the bread, the cup, the gathering, the name. And Paul says the reality was absent. Chilling precisely because it is so *ordinary*: no golden calf, just a church doing the right ceremony in the wrong way.
- **Paul's own conscience** (fourth click, Acts 23:1): the capstone, and the pastoral heart of the slide. "I have lived my life with a clear conscience before God to this day." Paul says this *truthfully*, and he had persecuted the church, dragged believers to prison, consented to Stephen's death, all with that same clear conscience (Acts 26:9–11). Paul is the Bible's Exhibit A that sincerity and correctness are different faculties. **A clean conscience is a gift; it is not proof that you are right.** This sentence disarms "but I really mean it" before anyone can raise it in discussion.

Transition: "So if not sincerity, and not results: what *is* the standard?"

Segment 4: The Principle (38:00–45:00 · Slide 5)

Romans' bookends (first click): the obedience of faith opens the letter (1:5) and closes it (16:26). Paul frames his entire masterwork with the phrase; this is him telling us what the gospel is *for*. Tie the arc together: Week 1 named the obedience of faith, Week 2 placed it atop the stack, and today we have watched its opposite play out from Leviticus to Corinth.

Faith defined (second click): not merely belief. Faith hears God's word, trusts His wisdom, and walks in the way He revealed, *even when another way looks easier, cheaper, or more effective.* That clause is the exact temptation in every case on the table: the cart was easier, Jeroboam's calves were cheaper than pilgrimage, Moses' strike was faster.

Institution vs. expedient (third click): the practical tool the class needs, drawn from Restoration teaching. An *institution* is what God established; we have no authority to change it. An *expedient* is a lawful aid that helps carry out what God commanded without altering it. Carrying the Ark by poles on Levites' shoulders was the institution; a smoother road, a padded shoulder, a written schedule, all of which would have been expedients. The cart did not *aid* the institution; it *replaced* it. That is the line.

Handle this category with real care. Give only clearly-neutral examples (pews, sound systems, meeting times, translations aid worship without redefining it). Do *not* issue verdicts on contested practices from the front; reasonable believers who share this whole framework disagree about where specific lines fall, and if you spend your authority ruling on hot-button specifics, you lose the principle in a fight over applications. Teach the *category*; let the class reason the cases.

The governing question (fourth click): say all three aloud: "Will this work?" … "Do we mean well?" … "Has God spoken?" and let the third land alone. Close with 1 Corinthians 4:6, "do not go beyond what is written." Then go straight to discussion.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "Why does 'it works' feel like divine approval?" The instinct is deep and not foolish: in almost all of life, results *do* validate methods. Medicine, farming, engineering, business: if it works, it's right. Scripture's correction is that worship is categorically different, because its object is a *Person with revealed preferences*, not a problem to be solved. You cannot reverse-engineer how to please someone from whether your approach "worked." Moses' rock is the proof: it worked (the water came), and he was barred. Steer the room to that verse.

Q2: "Where do we build 'new carts' today?" This is the valuable question and the dangerous one. It can slide into grievance-airing about your own congregation's practices. **Keep it on the category, not the cases.** If someone names a hot-button local practice, don't rule on it; redirect into Berean method: "Good test case. Is it an institution or an expedient, and by what Scripture? Let's reason it,

not vote on it." Model reasoning-from-the-text over verdict-issuing; that *is* the course's method, enacted. The guardrail line is on the slide (final click); read it aloud if the room drifts.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min): signal the turn. Three weeks of "sincerity isn't enough" can leave a thoughtful class anxious: *am I sincere-but-wrong too?* Name it and point forward: "We've spent three weeks on the diagnosis. Next week, the cure." Romans 9:30–10:13 is the assignment, with the flag to watch for 10:3: Israel "seeking to establish their own righteousness" rather than submitting to God's, which is the sincerity-problem lifted from worship-method up to the level of salvation itself. Preview Unit II. Carry sentence. Close on David's verdict once more, and dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"Isn't it unfair that Uzzah died for an instinct, when he was trying to help?" Take the discomfort seriously; the text does too (David himself is angry and afraid, 2 Sam 6:8–9). Three things. First, the account is not primarily about Uzzah's individual guilt but about a national failure: David says *"the LORD our God attacked **us***" (1 Chr 15:13); Uzzah stood at the point where a corporate presumption came due. Second, the Ark was the visible throne of God's holiness among a people who had grown casual with it; the severity marks how real that holiness is, at a founding moment. Third, notice what David does with the lesson: not resentment, but correction: he learns *how* and does it right, and the second procession is pure joy (2 Sam 6:12–15). The account is recorded so we would learn the same without paying the same.

"Are you saying details matter more than the heart?" No, the opposite. The details are how the heart is *expressed* toward a God who has spoken. A husband who ignores everything his wife has actually asked for, while insisting his heart is full of love, has a heart problem, not merely a details problem. Uzzah's generation had grown casual enough with God's revealed will that they never checked it; that *is* a heart condition. Heart and obedience are not rivals; obedience is what a trusting heart does (John 14:15).

"Doesn't this make worship joyless, with everyone terrified of a wrong move?" It should do the reverse. The second Ark procession, done God's way, is one of the most joyful scenes in Scripture, with David dancing with all his might (2 Sam 6:14). Knowing how God wants to be approached *frees* worship from anxiety; it is not-knowing, or guessing, that breeds fear. The question "Has God spoken?" is answered in Scripture, not left to intuition, which is a mercy, not a burden.

"Who decides what's an institution versus an expedient?" Scripture does, by what it commands versus what it leaves open, and that is exactly the Berean work the course is training. Where the Bible commands a thing, it is an institution; where it commands an end but leaves the means open, the means is an expedient. Honest believers will disagree on specific cases, and that disagreement is legitimate ground for study, which is why we reason from the text rather than issuing rulings. Flag that Weeks 10–11 return to this when we reach church order.

"Was Paul lost while he had a clear conscience persecuting Christians?" Yes, and he says so plainly: "I was formerly a blasphemer and a persecutor and an arrogant man" who acted "ignorantly

in unbelief" (1 Tim 1:13). Sincerity did not save him; grace did, when Christ stopped him on the road. This is precisely why next week matters: sincerity in building your own righteousness (Rom 10:3) is the very thing that has to be surrendered. Paul is the course's bridge from Unit I to Unit II.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read all six pattern accounts in full, especially Numbers 20 (the water really came) and 1 Kings 12 (Jeroboam's reasoning is stated)
- [ ] Read 2 Samuel 6:1–15 whole, so you can end Uzzah on the *joyful* second procession, not the death
- [ ] Decide your two or three clearly-neutral expedient examples in advance (pews / sound / translation)
- [ ] Pre-plan your redirect line for when Q2 names a local hot-button practice
- [ ] Rehearse the table walk against the clock: ~2.5 min/row, Moses gets the most
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with the 10:3 flag
- [ ] Confirm animations run On Click; note that slide 3 (table) has none by design

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress Saul-at-Gilgal and Uzziah on the table to one sentence each (Moses and Jeroboam carry the argument); trim the Ananias click on slide 4 to a single line; drop the institution/expedient *examples* (keep the definitions). **Never cut:** Moses' rock (the whole discussion hinges on it), David's own diagnosis on slide 2, Paul's clear conscience on slide 4, or the three-part governing question on slide 5. If discussion must shrink, keep Q1 (it's the intellectual key) and hold Q2 for a follow-up week; it rewards more time than a rushed five minutes allows.